

# Knowledge, Knower, and Known

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**Edited on:** June 28, 2026, 7:49 PM IST **The question:** What is knowledge, who is the knower, and what is it that one can know? How do we ground these concepts in experience, and how does the Co-existentialism of Shri A. Nagraj compare with the non-dualism of Advaita Vedanta and the physicalism of modern science and philosophy?

This study examines knowledge, the knower, and the knowable in **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), as presented by **Shri A. Nagraj**, and compares its answers with **Advaita Vedanta** and **modern science and philosophy**.

[The Ontology of Coexistence](#) states coexistence, saturation, and the four orders; it defers epistemological machinery here — the four senses of *gyan*, staged study and experiment, conduct-evidence and *pramanikta*, full-knowability, and the epistemic status of knower persistence across bodily death. This study develops those topics and compares them with Advaita and modern epistemology. Spiritual practice (*dhyān*, yoga), assembly governance, and the Saturation-Reflector physics belong in linked studies (*Spiritual-Practice-And-Realization*, governance and society studies, [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §6.2.10).

## Standpoint and scope

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These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture of nature is hard to avoid: **consciousness appears as something the brain does** — an epiphenomenon, functional outcome, or emergent property of particular configurations of very large numbers of physical particles. Modern physics and cognitive science are powerful on mechanism, prediction, and public evidence; yet the hard problem of consciousness, the status of the self, and the reality of value remain fiercely contested. The standpoint taken here does not treat those gaps as settled in favour of matter-only reductionism.

The work begins where that scientific picture leaves open questions — and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. This paper reads the primary texts carefully, states what follows from the darshan itself, and compares it in parallel with what we know from **physics and the natural sciences**, **Advaita Vedanta**, and **modern Western philosophy** (especially epistemology and philosophy of mind). Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

## 1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

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Madhyasth Darshan holds that knowledge is the realization of coexistence evidenced as wisdom, science, and humane conduct; the knower is the active sentient self (*jeevan*) operating through the human body in seer-status (*drishta-pad*); and the knowable is existence itself — Omnipresence and all real units in their relationships, orderliness, and conduct. For Shri A. Nagraj, knowledge (*gyan*) is not a subjective construct, a private mental state, or a mere collection of information. It has an ontological base, an epistemic structure, and a practical test.

### 1.1 Space as knowledge

In its ultimate sense, Space (*shunya / vyapak*) is not empty nothingness. It is omnipresent, transparent, all-pervasive, and the uniform energy in which all units are saturated. This omnipresent Space is itself Knowledge:

**“Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence. This itself is referred to as Space.”**

— MVD, p. 35

**“The Space (Omnipresence) itself is knowledge. Omnipresence itself is Omnipotence.”**

— MVD, p. 143

**“Space itself is knowledge, knowledge itself is Omnipresence,”**

— MVD, p. 155

Importantly, Space here is not an individual conscious subject and not a unit among other units. It is the omnipresent, non-transforming medium in which all material (*jada*) and sentient (*chaitanya*) units are submerged, energised, regulated, and conserved. The sentient knower is still *jeevan*, not Space itself.

*Gyan* here names a **condition of intelligibility** — reality is such that it can be known, is orderly, transparent, and lawful — rather than an act of cognition. Omnipresence is “Knowledge” the way a perfectly legible text is meaning even when no one is reading it. The knowing act (*chaitanya*) belongs only to *jeevan*.

MVD p. 289 states explicitly that **the unfolding of knowledge** (*gyan udghatan*) occurs **only** through the sentient aspect (*jeevan*) or thoughts — not through insentient units and not through Omnipresence acting as a knower. MVD p. 115 adds a narrower formulation: knowledge is inherent everywhere, but **its unfolding happens by awakened humans** — a sleeping, deluded *jeevan* cannot unfold it. The same passage describes a sensory/cognitive

pathway: vibrational motion on the brain from the cognitive organs leads to the unfolding of knowledge. So *gyan* as a name of *satta* is the intelligibility-ground; *gyan udghatan* is an activity exclusive to awakened *jeevan*.

That is why Omnipresence can be called Knowledge without being a knowing subject — and why a careless reading of MVD p. 35 collapses straight into Advaita’s *chit* (Brahman as awareness itself), exactly the identification Madhyasth Darshan otherwise resists. SB lists several English names for the same *satta* — Uniform Energy, Space, Knowledge, Consciousness, Omnipresence, Eternity, God, and Absolute Energy (SB, p. 48). **Consciousness** and **Knowledge** in that list do not mean a mind that knows; sentience as the activity of a knower belongs to *jeevan*, not to Omnipresence itself. *Satta* is actionless (*kriya-shunya*) as ground; calling it “Consciousness” in English invites the Advaita misreading this section resists. All units saturated in permeative *gyan* participate in inherent orderliness (MVD, p. 11; [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.3); the ontology paper develops how ever-present *gyan* is expressed as active sentience only when a constitutionally complete atom acts as a stable reflector — the **Saturation-Reflector Model** ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.3, §6.6).

### 1.1.1 Four senses of knowledge in coexistence

The texts use *gyan* and related words at **four distinct senses**. Treating them as one thing is the main source of misreading ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.11). The epistemic task is to keep them apart while tracing how they connect in human knowing:

| Sense                                                   | What it names                                  | Primary locus                                       | Epistemic role                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Realisation Knowledge</b><br>( <i>anubhav jnan</i> ) | Orderliness already present in saturated units | All units in Omnipresence (MVD, p. 11)              | Ontological <b>given</b> — what exists to be known              |
| <b><i>Gyan</i> as *satta*</b>                           | Intelligibility-ground; Space as knowledge     | Omnipresence (MVD, p. 35)                           | Condition of intelligibility — not a knowing subject (§1.1)     |
| <b>Realisation in coexistence</b>                       | Relationships fulfilled and evident            | Knowledge order telos (MVD, p. 116; SB, p. 51)      | <b>Goal</b> of complete knowing — not a new state of the ground |
| <b><i>Gyan udghatan</i></b>                             | Unfolding of knowledge in thought and conduct  | Awakened <i>jeevan</i> only (MVD, pp. 115–116, 289) | <b>Activity</b> of the knower — exclusive to awakened humans    |

**Realisation Knowledge** is stated at the opening of MVD’s unit doctrine:

**“All units saturated in the Omnipresence (permeative and transparent) have form, properties, essential nature & dharma, and have inherent orderliness & participate in overall orderliness.”**

— MVD, p. 11

This is knowledge as an ontological given in every saturated unit — not yet the human accomplishment of understanding. **Gyan as \*satta (§1.1)** names the ground’s state-complete intelligibility. Realisation in coexistence is the telos when relationships are fulfilled and made evident — nature saturated in Omnipotence is oriented toward development and awakening until realisation in coexistence (SB, p. 51). **Gyan udghatan** is the exclusive activity by which awakened jeevan\* unfolds what is given into lived understanding, wisdom, and science (§1.2).

Orderliness in all saturated units and active sentience at constitutional completeness are distinct senses; conflating them produces either pan-knowing Omnipresence or a world with no inherent intelligibility. Comparative work must not collapse *gyan* as *satta* into Advaita’s *chit* (§4.2).

## 1.2 Knowledge as *gyan-vivek-vigyan*

When realized by the human being, knowledge becomes evident as wisdom and science, not as belief alone:

**“The realisation in coexistence itself is the unfolding of knowledge. The study is in, by and for realisation in coexistence. Knowledge itself is evident in the form of wisdom and science.”**

— MVD, p. 35

This gives Madhyasth Darshan a distinctive epistemic structure:

1. **Gyan** — understanding reality as coexistence.
2. **Vivek** — wisdom/discrimination that evaluates life by justice, dharma, and truth rather than only pleasure, health, and profit.
3. **Vigyan** — science or systematic knowledge that enables right experiment, production, and participation in orderliness.

Knowledge is not only contemplative. It must become correct perspective, correct evaluation, and correct practical participation.

## 1.3 The threefold content of complete knowledge

In human life, knowledge has three inseparable areas:

**“1. Knowledge of jeevan 2. Knowledge of holistic view of existence 3. Knowledge of humane conduct”**

— SB, p. 116

To have complete knowledge (*paripoorna gyan*) means to understand the nature of the self (*jeevan*), the structure of existence as coexistence (*saha-astitva*), and how to live in harmony with other humans and nature (humane conduct).

#### **1.4 Worldview, scene, and perspective (*darshan-drishya-drishhti*)**

Madhyasth Darshan does not begin from a detached subject staring at external objects. It describes a perceiver using a perspective to see the scene, and the successful accomplishment of this process is understanding:

**“The activity and process that a perceiver uses through their perspective for seeing the scene itself is worldview, the accomplishment from which is the understanding or knowledge.”**

— MVD, p. 84

Here:

1. **Drishya (scene)** is the world of activities — existence as it appears in the present.
2. **Drishhti (perspective)** is the act of seeing, understanding, recognizing, and evaluating realities.
3. **Darshan (worldview / holistic view)** is the accomplished understanding obtained through right perspective.

The aim of this structure is alignment. When the human’s perspective becomes aligned with coexistence, the scene is understood as it is, and that understanding is then evidenced in conduct. Knowing here is therefore not detached observation but the disciplined use of perspective until reality is seen correctly, realized first-hand, and fulfilled in relationships.

##### **1.4.1 Relativity (*sapēkshata*)**

Madhyasth Darshan uses *sapēkshata* (relativity) in an epistemological sense, not as a synonym for Einstein’s physics. Relativity arises from the distinctions among perspective (*drishhti*), scene (*drishya*), and holistic view (*darshan*): qualification yields perspective, perspective organises how the scene is seen and evaluated, and the worldview accomplished through that process is never a view from nowhere. Different *drishhti* — lower or humane, deluded or awakened — therefore yield different relative understandings of the same real activities in existence. The six evaluative perspectives provisioned in *jeevan*’s design — lower *priya/hita/labh* and humane *nyaya/dharma/satya* — are the ontological basis for which *drishhti* is active ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.10.1).

This is not a claim that relativity is unreal or that the scene is finally *mithya*. The distinctions belong to units, viewing, and understanding in the knowledge order — to how *jeevan* participates in *gyan udghatan* through study, evaluation, and conduct — not to the underlying reality of coexistence itself. Omnipresence, unit beingness, and structural relationships remain real whether or not any particular human has yet aligned perspective with coexistence. What is relative is the evaluative seeing and the understanding a *jeevan* has yet to evidence; what is absolute is coexistence as such (§1.11).

## 1.5 Knowing, believing, recognizing, and fulfilling

Knowledge is expressed dynamically in human behaviour through four interconnected activities: *janna* (knowing), *manna* (believing), *pahchanna* (recognizing), and *nirvaha karna* (fulfilling):

**“What is knowledge? Knowing and believing constitute knowledge.”**

— *JV*, p. 165

In a deluded human, believing is separated from knowing (believing without knowing). In an awakened human, they are unified:

**“Believe what is known Know what is believed”**

— *MVD*, p. 12

When we *know* existence as coexistence and *believe* in this reality, we spontaneously *recognize* our relationships with all units in nature and *fulfill* our values (justice, trust, cooperation) in behaviour. In the knowledge order, recognition and fulfilment pass through **capacity**, **ability**, and **receptivity** (*kshamata*, *yogyata*, *patrata*) — the mechanism by which relationship-expectations become lived conduct ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.4).

## 1.6 The evidence chain: realization, behaviour, experiment

Madhyasth Darshan’s test of knowledge is not private conviction alone. The text gives a practical evidence chain:

**“Realisation – Behaviour – Experiment”**

— *MVD*, p. 12

**“Realisation itself is the ultimate evidence, Evidence itself is the understanding or knowledge, Understanding itself is manifest, The manifest itself is resolution, work and behaviour, Work and behaviour itself is evidence, Evidence itself is awakened tradition, Awakened tradition itself is coexistence.”**

— *MVD*, p. 12

This is why humane conduct is not an ethical appendix to knowledge. It is part of the verification of knowledge. If a person claims to know coexistence but cannot evidence resolution, justice, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence in living, the knowledge has not yet become complete evidence.

### 1.6.1 Authentic evidence, *pramanikta*, and false learning

The evidence chain closes only when realization becomes **authentic conduct** (*pramanikta*) — living proof that understanding has taken hold, not merely correct opinion or legal compliance. At conduct completeness (T3), awakened humans evidence orderliness with living proof ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.10). *Pramanikta* is therefore the epistemic standard for complete knowing: realization evidenced outwardly, transmissible in awakened tradition (§1.8).

Knowing can fail even when activity continues. MVD names **false learning** (*avidya* in this register) as the tendency of doubt and misunderstanding — over-evaluation, under-evaluation, and mis-evaluation:

**“False learning (the tendency of doubt and misunderstanding, i.e. the tendency of over-evaluation, under-evaluation, and mis-evaluation)”**

— MVD, p. 263

Alongside delusion (*bhram*, §1.10), legality without justice, accumulation detached from right-use, and fear as lack of wisdom, false learning marks knowledge-order failures when the evidence chain has not closed (MVD, pp. 263–264; [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.13). A person may study, speak, or follow rules yet remain stuck in doubt, mis-evaluate relationships, or fail to evidence resolution in conduct — activity without authentic proof. Assembly-scale outcomes when the justice cycle closes belong in ethics and society studies; here the epistemic point is that **incomplete evidence** is a distinct failure mode from outright delusion about *jeevan* and the body.

### 1.7 Realization (*anubhuti*)

Ultimate knowledge is direct realization in coexistence, but this realization is expected to become visible in thought, behaviour, and experiment:



**“The realisation in coexistence itself is the complete knowledge.”**

— MVD, p. 116

**“Realisation in knowledge (gyan-anubhuti): - Realisation in the ultimate truth”**

— MVD, p. 316

**“delusion-less knowledge (nirbhram gyan): - Knowing, understanding and imparting the understanding of the realities the way they are.”**

— MVD, p. 317

## 1.8 Study, realization, and the proof of conveying

In Madhyasth Darshan all means of knowing converge on one outcome: direct realization in coexistence, which is then validated in living and in the ability to impart understanding to another.

**“The proof of our comprehension lies in our ability to convey it to others; this is the litmus test of our wisdom.”**

— JV, p. 26

Perception and reasoning are necessary but preliminary; the decisive proof (*pramana*) is realization (*anubhav*) evidenced as authentic conduct (*pramanikta*). This is why the evidence chain above begins with realization rather than with sense data.

### 1.8.1 Staged study, experiment, and practice

Madhyasth Darshan’s method of knowing is **staged**: study leads to experiment and practice, which culminate in realization with evidence in conduct ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.14). The stages are not interchangeable with modern laboratory procedure alone.

**Study** (*adhyayan*) is oriented toward realization in coexistence from the outset: “The study is in, by and for realisation in coexistence” (MVD, p. 35). It proceeds through awakened tradition — stepwise guidance from one who has realization (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 273), emulation of just behaviour, and abiding in resolved, dharma-based thoughts (§1.11.2). **Sanskara** — acceptances toward completeness and knowledge carried forward toward resolution — mediates transmission across generations (MVD, p. 90). Awakening, *sanskara*, environment, study, and humaneness form an explicit circular dependency (MVD, p. 290): knowing is never purely private cognition but participation in a living line of understanding.

**Experiment** (*prayog*) in this darshan names participation in orderliness through production, right-use, and practical verification — the *vigyan* leg of *gyan-vivek-vigyan* (§1.2). It is the middle term in “Realisation – Behaviour – Experiment” (MVD, p. 12): realization must become behaviour, and behaviour must be tested in lived experiment — work, production, and participation that can succeed or fail in the world. This is not Popperian hypothesis-test-



ing alone, though it shares the demand that claims face correction in activity. Objective truth (§1.11) is what can be evidenced and shared in experiment and tradition.

**Practice** (*abhyas*) and inward regulation (*dhyan*) supply the conditions under which study and experiment do not collapse into false learning (§1.6.1). The four supports of §1.11.2 — universal orderliness, social conduct, study and *sanskar*, inward regulation — are what make reflection upward possible rather than merely asserted.

Together, the stages tie §1.6's evidence chain to §1.11's path out of mystery: staged study until holistic view, experiment until conduct evidences understanding, practice until *pramanikta* closes the cycle.

## 1.9 Sensitivity and comprehension

Madhyasth Darshan distinguishes two modes by which a human engages the world. *Sensitivity* is body- and sense-based responsiveness — the mode humans share with animals, oriented to pleasure, health, and profit. *Comprehension* (cognisance) is the understanding proper to *jeevan*, oriented to relationship, value, and orderliness. Knowing in the full sense requires both, held in balance:

**“...the recognising and fulfilling of the insentient and the sentient world is through the balance of cognisance and sensitivity.”**

— *SB*, p. 64

The human predicament, in this view, is that we have so far lived almost entirely in sensitivity:

**“Thus far, humans have only lived within the purview of sensitivity; hence the issues of accumulation, comfort, revolt-rebellion and exploitation have kept coming up.”**

— *JV*, p. 166

To know existence as coexistence is precisely to rise from sense-bound sensitivity to *jeevan*'s comprehension.

## 1.10 Error and delusion (*bhram*)

Any account of knowledge needs an account of error. In Madhyasth Darshan, error is not the presence of a false object but a specific misidentification: taking *jeevan* to be the body, which forces life to run on inherited belief rather than understanding.

**“This adherence to ‘belief’ rather than ‘knowledge’ forms the basis of delusion.”**

— JV, p. 93

**“The root of delusion lies in identifying jeevan with the body.”**

— JV, p. 93

The correction is not negation of the world but accurate recognition — “*jeevan* should be recognised as *jeevan*, and the body as the body” (JV, p. 93). Error is therefore removable in principle, through study and realization, rather than an irreducible feature of the knowing situation.

### 1.11 Truth and the removability of mystery

Madhyasth Darshan recognizes truth in three registers — absolute, relative, and objective — and treats their transmission as the very source of reality in human tradition:

**“The tradition of imparting the understanding of absolute truth, relative truth, and objective truth is itself the source of reality.”**

— MVD, p. 37

The **relative** register names truths that hold within the *darshan-drishya-drishti* structure (§1.4.1) — perspective-dependent understanding of units, relationships, and conduct. The **absolute** register names coexistence as such. The **objective** register names what can be evidenced and shared in activity, experiment, and tradition. Neither the relative nor the objective register cancels the reality of units or the world; *sapēkshata* marks the epistemic domain of viewing and understanding, not an intermediate ontological status like Advaita’s *mithya* (§4.2).

From this follows one of the darshan’s sharpest epistemological commitments: existence is *fully knowable*, and “mystery” is not a permanent horizon but a removable deficit of understanding.

**“The incompleteness in understanding the absolute state and the activity, is mystery.”**

— MVD, p. 209

**“Eradication of mystery is only through the holistic view of reality.”**

— MVD, p. 209

Madhyasth Darshan asserts that right understanding culminates in certitude, not residual mystery: “The holistic view of reality leads to ‘certitude’; otherwise, doubt persists” (MVD, p. 209).

MVD Ch. 17 (*Rahasya-mukti*, Liberation from Mystery) sharpens the same doctrine at the level of the knower. Mystery is not revealing understanding, not being able to reveal it, or not attaining complete understanding; the incapacity for this is *rahasyata* (mysteriousness):

**“Not revealing understanding or not being able to do so, or not being able to attain it, is a mystery. The incapacity for this is ‘mysteriousness’.”**

— MVD, Ch. 17, p. 273

Page 209 states the epistemic commitment; Ch. 17 states the **mechanism and path** by which incomplete understanding persists in the knowledge order and is removed. Only humans attain complete understanding through the realization-based method in coexistence (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 273); the *dharma* of a unit is realized, not grasped by description alone, through study and stepwise guidance from one who has realization (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 273). This is not the Hard Problem of consciousness (glossary): Madhyasth Darshan locates *rahasyata* in the knower’s incomplete reflection, not in an irreducible opacity of coexistence itself ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §§1.9–1.10, §1.11).

### 1.11.1 Intellectual mystery and the knower’s misalignment

The root misidentification named in §1.10 — *jeevan* taken for the body — propagates through the knower’s inner structure. In delusion, hope in *mun* follows sensation upward from the body; in awakening, realization in coexistence at *atma* regulates *buddhi*, *chitta*, *vritti*, and *mun* through the same projection–reflection cycle (*paravartan* and *pratyavartan*). When lower faculties do not take refuge in the one above, the texts call this *bauddhik rahasya* (intellectual mystery) — misalignment within *jeevan*, not an ontological limit on what exists (MVD, Ch. 17, pp. 274–277, 279). The ontology study develops the cycle in full ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.9); here the epistemic point is that **error in knowing** takes the form of discord among the faculties that should carry reflection upward.

Until *atma-bodh*, ego (*ahankar*) underlies knowing: *buddhi* without *atma-bodh* is ego, which appears as conceit in *chitta*, stubbornness in *vritti*, and attachment and agitation in *mun* (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 279). At the root of agitation lies stubbornness, at the root of stubbornness delusion, at the root of delusion ego (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 292). Delusion is therefore not only inherited belief about the body; it is a **structured failure of reflection** in the active knower described in §1.12.

Why another person’s awakening can look equally “mysterious” while one’s own decline feels inevitable uses the same structure: the means (*sadhan*) are shared; only the direction of the cycle differs (MVD, Ch. 17, pp. 295–296). The appearance of mystery here is failure to understand reflection–direction, not evidence of hidden forces in existence.

### 1.11.2 Uprooting mystery: paths and conditions of valid knowing

MVD Ch. 17 names a definite process for ending intellectual mystery. Only through practising and behaving according to this process can *bauddhik rahasya* be eliminated (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 280). The process is of two kinds:

**Exploration** (*anushandhan*) is inventive realisation: comprehensive study from the initial state of activity or extreme decline through development and awakening to omnipresence, until the seeker sees the entire decline-and-development chain, the self, and the goal of all humankind as capacity for realisation in omnipresence (MVD, Ch. 17, pp. 280–281).

**Following, emulation, and study** in awakened tradition summarises as: (1) emulating just behaviour, and (2) abiding in resolved, dharma-based thoughts. Firmness in both yields authority for realisation of verity and immersion of *buddhi* in truth (MVD, Ch. 17, pp. 282–283).

Successful **reflection** (*pratyavartan*) — the upward regulation by which behaviour becomes thought, thought desire, desire resolve, and resolve realization — requires four supports working together (MVD, Ch. 17, pp. 284–285, 291–292):

1. **Universal orderliness** — for behaviour without crime.
2. **Social conduct** — for thoughts without injustice.
3. **Study and *sanskar*** — for desire without attachment.
4. **Inward regulation** (*dhyān*) — for *buddhi* without ignorance.

Concentration (*dhyān*) here means focusing *mun*, *vritti*, *chitta*, and *buddhi* to understand, then to evidence after understanding and realization (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 284). These are epistemic conditions for valid knowing, not optional moral extras: they are what makes the evidence chain of §1.6 and the proof-by-conveying of §1.8 possible rather than merely asserted. The detailed practice of *dhyān*, the six flaws of delusion, and yoga as union belong in the planned study *Spiritual-Practice-And-Realization*; this section states only the epistemic architecture Ch. 17 presupposes.

Internal regulation together with humane orderliness, social conduct, study, and *sanskar* is what makes accomplishment of highest development (awakening) possible (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 285). Becoming established in just behaviour, dharma-based thoughts, and truth-realisation-based desires is complete awakening in the epistemic sense (MVD, Ch. 17, pp. 283–285).

### 1.11.3 Certitude, delusion-less knowledge, and liberation from mystery

The arc closes where §1.11 opened: holistic view yields certitude (MVD, p. 209); delusion-less knowledge (*nirbhram gyan*) is knowing, understanding, and imparting realities as they are (MVD, p. 317; §1.7). MVD Ch. 17 adds the outcome in the knower's own terms: the accomplishment of mental wellbeing or bliss itself is liberation from mystery (MVD, Ch. 17, p. 301). Mystery removed is not a blank positivism but realized harmony — *gyan* unfolded as *vivek* and *vigyan* (§1.2) and evidenced in conduct.

Madhyasth Darshan contrasts this with mystery-based traditions that treat ultimate knowledge as unmanifest and ineffable ([Human Behavior and Society](#) §3): here knowledge is manifest, effable, studyable, and verifiable through behaviour. The contrast is epistemic — what counts as adequate knowing — not a dismissal of other traditions’ ethical or contemplative achievements.

### 1.12 Who is the knower?

The knower (*gyata* or *drishta*) is the sentient self — **jeevan** — operating through the human body. Specifically, the human being is the locus where seer-status can be evidenced:

**“The noteworthy points here are: 1. In coexistence, the human being is integrally and indivisibly present. 2. In existence, the human being is a seer (observer).”**

— *SB*, p. 188

**“The human being alone is the seer-status in existence.”**

— *SB*, p. 239

Material things (like stones) and biological organisms (like plants) do not have the capacity to know. Animals have sensory awareness and react to pain or pleasure, but they cannot evaluate existence. Only the human being belongs to the **knowledge order** (*gyan avastha*) and has the capacity of understanding. However, this capacity must be awakened:

**“Only awakened humans are recognisable in the seer status.”**

— *MVD*, p. 33

This distinction is important: every human has the possibility of seer-status because every human has imagination, freedom of action, and the capacity for understanding; only the awakened human evidences that status in living.

In the human order, knowledge-unfolding is additionally **sanskar-mediated**: acceptances toward completeness, and knowledge, wisdom, and science carried forward toward resolution for evidencing (*MVD*, p. 90). Awakening, *sanskar*, environment, study, and humaneness form an explicit circular dependency (*MVD*, p. 290). Insentient units do not unfold knowledge; only *jeevan* does, through thought — a point developed in the ontology study at [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.11.

Evaluation and proof of understanding are activities of *jeevan*, not mechanical outputs of the body. Values and evaluation are processes of understanding; they are not bodily or mechanical processes (*JV*, p. 39). *Jeevan* evaluates the values that emanate from itself; no external instrument is needed for this evaluation (*JV*, p. 139). Third-person instruments measure body-states; they do not substitute for *jeevan*’s evaluative knowing. The human body is nevertheless provisioned to **evidence** understanding, not merely to house brain activity (*JV*, p. 59): conduct, speech, work, and tradition are the public face of comprehension.

The knower in Madhyasth Darshan is therefore not an actionless, passive witness. *Jeevan* is an active, structured, sentient unit. Its activities include hope in *mun*, thought in *vriddhi*, desire in *chitta*, resoluteness in *buddhi*, and realization in *atma*. When these faculties are misaligned — lower layers not taking refuge in higher — the knower-side form of mystery named in §1.11.1 blocks complete knowing even though seer-status remains provisionally possible. (*Jeevan Vidya* presents the same structure as ten coordinated activities across the atom’s nucleus and orbits — taste and selection in *mun*, deliberation and analysis in *vriddhi*, contemplation and visualization in *chitta*, enlightenment and resolve in *buddhi*, and realization and authenticity in *atma* — JV, p. 92.) The body is the instrument through which this *jeevan* acts; the brain (*medhas*) receives and processes signals related to *jeevan*’s aspirations, desires, and evidence (MVD, p. 83). The inner self is thus understood as a real, active, constitutionally complete unit capable of awakening — not a passive or actionless witness.

### 1.12.1 Knowing through the joint form

Humans are a **joint form** of *jeevan* and body; the body is medium and instrument, not the sentient self ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §§1.9–1.10). Knowing in the knowledge order unfolds through this joint pathway. MVD p. 115 describes vibrational motion on the brain from the cognitive organs leading to the unfolding of knowledge — motion **within** the human as joint form, not an external force registered on a calorimeter. *Jeevan*’s “driving” of the body is therefore closer to **transmission of state, order, and informational structure** — which faculty is active, how resolve and desire are coordinated — than to supply of macroscopic kinetic energy from a separate substance ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §6.2.5).

That reading spares the crude Cartesian picture of an immaterial object pushing neurons. It does not settle whether *jeevan*’s coordination satisfies physical causal closure — Kim-style closure remains an open question (§6.3). Full treatment of joint-form causation and neural dynamics belongs in the planned *Philosophy-Of-Mind-And-Jeevan* study. Epistemically, the point is that first-person realization and third-person brain measurement describe **different legs** of the same joint activity: instruments track body-states; proof of understanding remains conduct-evidence and transmissibility (§1.8).

### 1.13 What is the knowable?

The knowable (*gyeya*) is **existence itself in the form of coexistence**. It includes Omnipresence and all units saturated in it:

**“All units saturated in the Omnipresence (permeative and transparent) have form, properties, essential nature & dharma, and have inherent orderliness & participate in overall orderliness.”**

— MVD, p. 11

To know something in Madhyasth Darshan is not merely to measure its external properties. It is to understand its form (*roop*), properties (*gun*), essential nature (*svabhav*), dharma, re-

relationships, value, and participation in overall orderliness. The knowable includes:

1. **The Four Orders of Nature:** The material order (*padarth avastha*), biological order (*pran avastha*), animal order (*jeev avastha*), and knowledge order (*gyan avastha*).
2. **Omnipresence and Units:** Space as the omnipresent medium, and all countable units saturated in it.
3. **The Laws of Nature:** Effort, motion, result, balance, integration, development, awakening, and participation in overall orderliness.
4. **Relationships and Values:** The mutual expectations through which units participate in one another.
5. **Humane Conduct:** Justice, values, evaluation, mutual satisfaction, resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence in human life.

Crucially, in Madhyasth Darshan, the known world is **absolutely real and perpetual** (*sa-tat*). It is not an illusion or a temporary mistake:

**“Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.”**

— MVD, *The Alternative*, point 8

Madhyasth Darshan therefore resolves the knower-known distinction by awakening the knower to the real coexistence of Omnipresence and world. The world is not negated; it is understood, recognized, and fulfilled in conduct.

### 1.14 The knower across bodily death

The knower *jeevan* is modeled as **constitutionally immortal** — a real sentient unit that does not begin at birth or end with bodily death. This is a separate commitment from coexistence conservation ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §1.12): bodies and configurations begin and end; *vastu* persists through transformation. *Jeevan* persistence is inferred from constitutional immortality together with conservation:

**“Nothing arrives at birth nor does anything depart with death. All that is, exists forever.”**

— JV, p. 20

**“Jeevan continues to exist even after death as it does while driving a body.”**

— JV, p. 20

**“That which exists continues to be, and that which was not, does not come into existence. Therefore, existence will remain as it is till eternity.”**

— SB, p. 49



**Epistemic status.** Within the darshan, post-death continuity of *this jeevan* is **philosophical inference**, not a theorem of public science. The texts move from conservation and the indestructibility of the constitutionally complete sentient unit to survival and re-association across bodies. From the standpoint of modern science, that inference risks a **category error**: physics conserves mass-energy and charge, but not specific configurations or functional identities. Thermodynamic conservation alone does not guarantee the immortality of a structured unit unless constitutional completeness is already assumed as a separate metaphysical axiom ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §6.2.4).

Madhyasth Darshan's reply — that at constitutional completeness the atom is liberated from molecular-bondage and weight-bondage — is ontological, not yet operational in physics. The epistemic question for this study is not whether the texts assert continuity (they do) but **what would count as independent evidence** beyond inference from conservation:

1. **Operational criteria** for constitutional completeness independent of the philosophy.
2. **Reproducible markers** distinguishing *jeevan*-mediated from brain-only activity.
3. **Independent evidence** for post-death continuity of a sentient unit.

Until those are met, *jeevan* persistence remains a metaphysical assertion compatible with co-existence conservation but not validated by current science — while the hard problem shows physicalism's own exposed point (§6.2). Mereology, composite decay, and weight-bondage exit are developed in [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §6.2.4; this section states only the **epistemic framing** the ontology paper presupposes.

## 2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

Advaita Vedanta holds that the true knower is the actionless witness Self (*Atman* / *sakshi*), identical to ultimate reality (*Brahman*); the known world of diversity is a dependent appearance (*mithya*); and knowledge is the direct realization of this non-duality, dissolving the distinction between knower, known, and knowing.

### 2.1 Seer and seen (*drig-drishya*)

Advaita Vedanta begins its inquiry by separating the Seer (*drig*) from the Seen (*drishya*). The fundamental rule of this discrimination (*viveka*) is that whatever is observed cannot be the observer:

**“The form1... is perceived and the eye... is its perceiver... It... is perceived and the mind... is its perceiver. The mind with... modifications is perceived and the Witness (the Self) is verily the perceiver... But... is not perceived...”**

— DDV, p. 15

Following this logic, the physical body is seen (observed), so it is not the Seer. Senses, emotions, and thoughts are also witnessed by the mind, so they are not the ultimate Seer. The ultimate Seer is **witness consciousness** (*sakshi-caitanya* / *Sakshin* / *Atman*). This witness is never an object of perception; it is the ultimate subject:

**“This body, O son of Kunti, is called the field; he who knows it is called the knower of the field.”**

— BG, 13.1

**“Know also that I am the Knower of the field in all fields, and the knowledge of the field also am I.”**

— BG, 13.2

The *Mandukya Upanishad* (MU, vv. 3–7) analyses **three states of experience** — waking, dream, and deep sleep — as objects witnessed from within. Each state presents a different “known”: the waking world, dream-images, or the blank of deep sleep. **Turiya**, the fourth, is not another state among them but the awareness in which all states appear. That first-person ladder is an epistemological route: it shows how whatever presents itself as known is always “seen,” never the seer.

The *Taittiriya Upanishad* (TU, 2.1–2.5) applies the same method through five **sheaths** (*kosha*): food-body, vitality, mind, intellect, and bliss — each discovered to be a covering the Self wears, not the Self (elaborated in VC, vv. 154–212). Notably, these are the same *kosha* terms Shri Nagraj reuses in Madhyasth Darshan — but to opposite epistemic effect: Advaita **negates** each layer to reveal the Self beyond all coverings; Madhyasth Darshan **affirms** layered human equipment harmonized in awakened living ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §5.7.2).

## 2.2 Sat-Chit-Ananda: knowledge as Brahman

A second classical formulation names existence not only as *sat* — bare being — but as **Sat-Chit-Ananda**: being-consciousness-bliss. These are not three realities added together; Brahman is one partless reality whose nature is expressed in three inseparable names.

**“Brahman is Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity.”**

— TU, 2.1.1

Shankara’s tradition reads *satyam* as being/reality, *jnanam* as consciousness, and *anantam* as the infinite. For Advaita, **chit** — consciousness — is the very nature of reality and Self, not a function of brain or mind. Consciousness is **self-luminous** (*svaprakasha*): it reveals itself and does not depend on another knower to be known — otherwise an infinite regress of witnesses would be required. The mature formula in the *Vivekachudamani* states:

**“By that alone he comes to know his own Self as Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute and becomes happy.”**

— VC, v. 152

Knowledge (*jnana*) in Advaita is therefore not information about an external world; it is the direct realization that the inner Self (*Atman*) is identical to Brahman. At *paramartha*, the knower-known-knowing triad is dissolved: there is only one partless awareness without a second.

### 2.2.1 Sublation and the removal of error

When Advaita says the world is sublated (*badhita*) upon knowledge of Brahman, it names a distinct epistemic process. **Sublation** (*badha*) is not ordinary correction of a false belief while leaving the underlying world intact; it is the discovery that what was taken as absolutely real was **dependent** on a substrate all along — like learning the snake was never there, only the rope. The rope-snake error is sublated; the rope remains. At *paramartha*, the entire plural world is sublated in this sense: not annihilated like a hallucination, but discovered to be *mithya* — dependent appearance on Brahman.

Madhyasth Darshan diverges: error is a **removable misidentification** within a fully real world (§1.10), not an indescribable appearance whose ultimate substrate cancels plurality. Advaita’s *khyati* treats cosmic error as *anirvacaniya* — indescribable as either absolutely real or sheer nothing — in Shankara’s “neither *sat* nor *asat*” register; later Advaita systematizes that as a technical status. Madhyasth Darshan treats mystery as removable deficit in the knower’s reflection (§1.11), not as the world’s final ontological status.

## 2.3 Three tiers of reality

Advaita’s standard framework separates private apparent errors (*pratibhasika*, such as a rope mistaken for a snake) from shared empirical reality (*vyavahara*, which governs bodies, physical laws, ethics, and scripture) and the absolute truth of Brahman (*paramartha*).

| Level                               | What is known?                                                 | Status of error                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Apparent<br>( <i>pratibhasika</i> ) | Rope-snake, dream objects,<br>private errors                   | Sublated by waking or correction                                                   |
| Empirical<br>( <i>vyavahara</i> )   | Bodies, minds, Ishvara, causes,<br>duties, scriptures, science | Shared, law-governed; operationally<br>valid; sublated only by <i>brahma-jnana</i> |
| Absolute<br>( <i>paramartha</i> )   | Brahman alone                                                  | World is <i>mithya</i> , dependent appearance                                      |

At *vyavahara*, the world is not unreal in the way a hallucination is; it is unreal **relative to Brahman** — like a dream relative to waking. This distinction matters when comparing

## 2.4 The nature of the knower

In absolute reality (*paramartha*), Brahman is one, without a second (*ekamevaditiam*, CU 6.2.1). Therefore, there cannot be multiple, separate individual knowers. The individual knower (*jiva* or *ahamkara*) is a provisional appearance arising due to ignorance (*avidya*).

This happens through **superimposition** (*adhyasa*): we superimpose the qualities of the physical body and mind (like “I am tall,” “I am sad”) onto the Self, and we superimpose the self-luminous consciousness of the Self onto the inert body-mind complex. The true Self is actionless (*akriya*) and does not do anything (BSB, *Adhyasa Bhashya*).

At *vyavahara*, the embodied soul (**jivatman**) is the true Self (*Atman*) **conditioned by limiting adjuncts** (*upadhi*) — body, mind, and the apparent separateness they confer. The adjuncts are real at the empirical tier; the separateness they seem to prove is not. **Ishvara** (Saguna Brahman) is Brahman associated with cosmic **Maya**, functioning as operative cause of ordered name-form manifestation — not a creator *ex nihilo*, but the *vyavahara*-level guarantor of law-governed world and scripture. Ishvara and *jiva* are both sublated at *paramartha*:

**“These two are the superimpositions of Ishvara and the Jiva respectively, and when these are perfectly eliminated, there is neither Ishvara nor Jiva.”**

— VC, v. 244

VC vv. 243–244 distinguish **Maya** (cosmic, Ishvara's superimposition) from **Avidya** (individual, the *jiva*'s superimposition of body-mind on the Self). Maya operates through **concealment** (*avarana*) of Brahman's true nature and **projection** (*vikshepa*) of diverse name-form — the epistemic starting point from which *viveka* must begin. Full causal and cosmological treatment: [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §2.4–§2.5.

## 2.5 The nature of the known

The known universe of diversity (objects, space, time, individuals) is **not absolutely real**. It is categorized as ***mithya*** — meaning it has dependent reality (like a clay pot which is nothing but clay, or a wave which is nothing but water):

**“My dear, as by the knowledge of one lump of clay alone all things made of clay are known — for all transformation has speech as its basis, it being name, while clay alone is real — so, my dear, is this knowledge.”**

— CU 6.1.4

**“A firm conviction of the mind to the effect that Brahman is real and the universe unreal, is designated as discrimination (Viveka) between the Real and the unreal.”**

— VC, v. 20

**“The individual soul is itself and directly the Supreme Brahman, and nothing else.”**

— VC, v. 216

The world appears real only as long as ignorance persists; once Brahman is realized, the world is sublated (*badhita*), and only Brahman remains as absolute knower-known ground (§2.2.1).

## 2.6 Means of knowledge and the theory of error

Advaita inherits the classical Indian analysis of valid knowledge (*pramana*) and accepts six means: perception (*pratyaksha*), inference (*anumana*), comparison (*upamana*), postulation (*arthapatti*), non-apprehension (*anupalabdhi*), and verbal testimony (*shabda*).

Advaita also offers a developed theory of error (*khyativada*). The stock example is mistaking a rope for a snake: the snake is neither real (it vanishes on knowledge) nor utterly unreal (it was genuinely experienced), but a projection on a real substrate — the same structure *Maya* writ large applies to the world until Brahman is known (§2.2.1). Cosmic **Maya** and individual **Avidya** are the two scales of that obscuration (§2.4).

First-person discrimination (*drig-drishya-viveka*, DDV) and *neti neti* (“not this, not this,” BU, 2.3.6) complement scripture by negating everything that presents itself as an object until only witnessing awareness remains.

### 2.6.1 *Pramanas* by tier and the threefold path

The six *pramanas* do not carry equal weight at every level of reality:

| Tier                | Competent <i>pramanas</i>                                                                                    | What they establish                                             |
|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>Pratibhasika</i> | Perception (within the error); correction by waking inference                                                | Private errors sublated                                         |
| <i>Vyavahara</i>    | Perception, inference, comparison, postulation, non-apprehension, <i>shabda</i> (scripture, science, ethics) | Shared empirical order, duties, causes, beginningless cosmology |

| Tier              | Competent <i>pramanas</i>                                                                      | What they establish                    |
|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| <i>Paramartha</i> | <i>Shabda</i> (Upanishadic revelation) processed through <i>manana</i> and <i>nididhyasana</i> | Non-dual <i>Atman–Brahman</i> identity |

Perception and inference are indispensable at *vyavahara* — for daily life, ethics, and science — but they **presuppose** the subject-object duality that *paramartha* transcends. They cannot by themselves establish that the witness is identical to Brahman; for that, **verbal testimony** (*shabda*) — the revealed word of the Upanishads — is finally competent when processed through reasoning and meditation.

The supreme path is classically threefold under a **qualified teacher** (*guru*):

1. ***Shravana*** — hearing the scriptures; the Upanishadic sentence imparted by one who knows.
2. ***Manana*** — reasoning until doubt is removed; inference in service of *shabda*, not against it.
3. ***Nididhyasana*** — sustained meditation until identity is directly realized.

**“The Self, my dear Maitreyi, should be realized — should be heard of, reflected on, and meditated upon.”**

— *BU*, 2.4.5

Transmission through an awakened teacher is not optional decoration. *Shabda* becomes valid knowledge only when the hearer understands, reflects, and meditates under guidance — structurally parallel to Madhyasth Darshan’s proof-by-conveying and awakened tradition (§§1.8, 1.8.1), though the content verified differs: identity with Brahman, not coexistence evidenced in conduct.

## 2.7 Liberation and complete knowledge

Complete knowledge in Advaita is **liberation** (*moksha*) — not acquisition of a new state but **recognition of pre-existing identity** with Brahman, in which the illusion of separate individuality is dispelled. The classical formula is *tat tvam asi* — “That thou art” (CU, 6.8.7, with Shankara’s commentary); BSB 1.1.2 treats the same doctrine systematically.

**“There is neither death nor birth, neither a bound nor a struggling soul, neither a seeker after Liberation nor a liberated one – this is the ultimate truth.”**

— VC, v. 574

**“The Supreme Brahman is, like the sky, pure, absolute, infinite, motionless and changeless, devoid of interior or exterior, the One Existence, without a second, and one’s own Self.”**

— VC, v. 393

Liberation is therefore not merger of a real individual into Brahman — the *jīva* was never a separate entity. What changes is **epistemic status**: the dispelled illusion of separateness. Realization **evidences** identity with Brahman — not Madhyasth Darshan’s four outcomes of resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence (§1.13), and not proof-by-conveying alone (§1.8), though the enlightened still teach at *vyavahara*.

## 2.8 Ethics, *loka-sangraha*, and what realization evidences

Advaita’s fair reply to the charge that *mithya* undermines ethics is substantial. At *vyavahara*, ethics and compassion remain fully valid; realization of non-duality deepens rather than weakens them. Shankara’s *Vivekachudamani* insists on ethical discipline as prerequisite to knowledge (VC, vv. 17–19). The Bhagavad Gita, in Shankara’s commentary, grounds social responsibility in *loka-sangraha* — holding the world together — and ordained duty (*niyatam kuru karma*, BG, 3.8): the enlightened still act for the welfare of the world.

What Advaita **provisions** at the empirical order must be distinguished from what realization **evidences** at *paramartha*. Ethics, scripture, causal law, and compassionate action prepare the mind for *brahma-jnana*; they are binding where humans actually live. None of this settles whether the world retains **final** ontological weight at the highest truth.

| Domain                           | Valid at <i>vyavahara</i>                                  | Status at <i>paramartha</i>                    |
|----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Ethics and duty</b>           | Binding; deepens with realization (VC, vv. 17–19; BG 3.8)  | Sublated as means; non-dual identity remains   |
| <b>World and nature</b>          | Law-governed, shared, beginningless cosmology              | <i>Mithya</i> — dependent appearance           |
| <b>Individual self</b>           | Real as embodied <i>jīva</i> under <i>upadhi</i>           | Identical with Brahman; separateness dispelled |
| <b>Relationships and society</b> | <i>Loka-sangraha</i> , ordained action for world-welfare   | Not ultimately separate from Brahman           |
| <b>Time and change</b>           | Past, present, future, birth and death operationally valid | Sublated when timeless Self is known           |



Madhyasth Darshan's counter-reply is narrower but precise: an ontology that makes the world *mithya* at *paramartha* cannot give the world the **same final weight** coexistence gives it — relationships and nature are ultimately sublated, not perpetual. The dispute is over final ontological status, not whether Advaitins can live ethically at the empirical level.

### 3. The Modern Scientific and Philosophical View

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Mainstream science and analytical philosophy answer that the knower is a biological organism whose brain processes generate the mind; the known is the physical universe of matter and energy; and knowledge is structured information validated by empirical testing, falsification, and intersubjective consensus. **Physicalism** — the view that every concrete phenomenon is physical (Strawson 2006) — is the default baseline in contemporary analytic philosophy and the natural sciences, even when philosophers dispute how mind, value, and the self fit within it ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §3).

The account proceeds in layers. It begins with **what counts as knowledge**, then **who the knower is**, then **what can be known** under third-person method. **The hard problem, error correction, personal identity**, and **method** follow — the topics §4 compares directly with Madhyasth Darshan's evidence chain and Advaita's *pramana* tiers. **Ethics and purpose** state how naturalism treats value and teleology. The section closes with **recent developments** that complicate simple brain-reduction.

#### 3.1 What is knowledge?

In modern science and analytical philosophy, knowledge is typically defined as **justified true belief** (in classical epistemology) or as **predictive modeling** (in cognitive science and naturalism). Neither formulation maps onto Madhyasth Darshan's four senses of *gyan* (§1.1.1): modern views have **no parallel taxonomy** that separates ontological intelligibility, realization telos, and knower-activity from information or belief.

1. **Methodological naturalism.** Knowledge is obtained by formulating hypotheses about the physical world and testing them against empirical evidence (Popper 1959). It requires intersubjective verification: anyone must be able to replicate the results using the same instruments.
2. **Information processing.** The brain builds neural networks that model the properties and behaviors of the environment (Kandel et al. 2021). These models are updated based on sensory feedback to optimize survival and action. **Information** and **belief** are therefore central categories; **knowledge** names a justified or reliable standing in that representational economy — not realization evidenced in conduct (§1.6).

The classical “justified true belief” analysis is itself contested from within. Gettier (1963) showed that one can hold a justified true belief that is intuitively *not* knowledge, launching a long debate over what further condition — reliability, safety, or sensitivity to truth — knowledge requires. Reliabilist and externalist theories treat knowledge as a true belief produced

by a dependable process; virtue epistemology adds intellectual character to the account. This unresolved difficulty over the very definition of “knowledge” sits alongside the more familiar metaphysical disputes about the knower and the known.

### 3.2 Who is the knower?

Mainstream physicalist accounts in modern science and philosophy reject the existence of any eternal, non-physical soul, *jeevan*, or *Atman*.

1. **The brain as the mind.** Consciousness and the sense of self are emergent properties of complex neuronal systems (Dennett 1991; Churchland 1986). There is no Cartesian theater or separate observer inside the brain; the **self** is a cognitive construct — a **self-model** integrated from sensory data, memory, and social recognition — rather than an indivisible sentient unit.
2. **Causal closure of the physical.** The physical universe is causally closed: every physical event (such as a muscle moving) is entirely caused by preceding physical events (such as motor neurons firing). There is no room for a non-physical entity (*jeevan* or *Atman*) to inject energy or intention into the nervous system without violating conservation or reducing to epiphenomenalism (Kim 2005).

The knower in this picture is therefore a **dynamic, evolving biological system** — not an actionless witness (§2.4) and not a constitutionally complete atom (§1.12). Evaluation and decision are modeled as neural and computational processes; there is no separate faculty that evaluates “without external instrument” in Madhyasth Darshan’s sense (JV, p. 139). Predictive-processing accounts (§3.9) deepen this picture by treating the organism as an active self-organising model-builder rather than a passive receiver of data.

### 3.3 What can be known?

The knowable, for established science, is the **objective, physical universe** of matter, energy, fields, and organisms — described through space-time, mathematical models, and law-governed regularities. **Scientific realism** treats this world as **mind-independent** and publicly investigable: electrons, brains, and ecosystems are real items suitable for measurement and theory change, not mere useful fictions. Instrumentalism and strong constructivism remain minority positions within mainstream analytic philosophy.

Mainstream science operationalises knowing through **subject-object structure**: an observer (individual scientist, instrument, or community) builds **testable models** of objects and events. This is the modern analogue of a seer–scene relation — but the observer is biological, the scene is physical, and the successful outcome is **predictive confirmation**, not holistic view or witness-realization (§4.1). Space-time in physics is a dynamical structure described mathematically — not omnipresent knowledge-energy ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §4.6; [Nature of Time](#)).

Claims that cannot be publicly observed, measured, mathematically modeled, or indirectly inferred through successful prediction remain **outside established scientific knowl-**

**edge.** That boundary matters for comparison: Madhyasth Darshan’s knowable includes **relationships, values, dharma, and humane conduct** as real features of existence (§1.13); naturalistic epistemology typically treats **normativity** as psychology, evolution, or social construction rather than as ontological givens knowable in Madhyasth Darshan’s sense. The **is–ought gap** (Hume’s fork) remains a standard constraint: descriptive science does not by itself yield prescriptive ethics without further premises.

### 3.4 The hard problem, mystery, and first-person evidence

Third-person method is powerful on mechanism and prediction, yet it leaves open the **Hard Problem of Consciousness**: why and how should physical brain processes give rise to subjective, first-person experience (Chalmers 1995; Nagel 1974)?

**“The really hard problem of consciousness is the problem of experience.”**

— Chalmers 1995, p. 3

**“the fact that an organism has conscious experience at all means, basically, that there is something it is like to be that organism.”**

— Nagel 1974, p. 1

The hard problem is not whether brains correlate with experience — they do — but why any physical process should have an **inside** at all. First-person experience is therefore an undeniable **datum** for philosophy: every observation is made through consciousness, even when science treats consciousness itself as something to be explained from the outside. Physicalists often treat the gap as **philosophically non-decisive** — an open theoretical frontier, not proof of extra-physical being. That stance differs sharply from Madhyasth Darshan’s *rahasyata* (§1.11): mystery there names **removable deficit in the knower’s reflection**, not a permanent opacity of nature. Science typically leaves consciousness **explanatorily open**; it does not claim that all mystery is eliminable through holistic view, nor that mystery is finally *anirvacaniya* (§2.2.1).

Some philosophers take panpsychism or realistic monism seriously — experience as fundamental or intrinsic to matter (Strawson 2006; Goff 2019; Hashemi 2025) — but these remain speculative interpretations rather than mainstream scientific findings (developed further in §3.9).

### 3.5 Error, bias, and correction

Modern science and philosophy need an account of **error** parallel to Madhyasth Darshan’s delusion and false learning (§§1.6.1, 1.10–1.11) and Advaita’s *khyati* (§2.2.1). The dominant naturalistic story treats error as **perceptual mistake, cognitive bias, or false belief** — not cosmic ignorance or misaligned reflection among *jeevan*’s faculties.

Sources of error include limited sensory resolution, heuristic shortcuts, motivated reasoning, publication bias, and statistical misuse. The institutional response is **replication, peer review, adversarial testing, and falsification** (Popper 1959): claims survive only when independent investigators reproduce results with the same instruments and methods. Gettier cases (§3.1) show that even **true, justified belief** may fail to be knowledge; replication culture addresses a different failure mode — beliefs that were justified within one lab or paradigm but do not survive public scrutiny.

This error regime is **third-person**: it corrects shared models of the physical world. It does not by itself correct **misidentification of self with body** or **conduct that fails to evidence understanding** — the failure modes Madhyasth Darshan foregrounds. Nor does it sublimate the world upon discovering Brahman. The contrast in §4 is over what error **is** and what **closes** the epistemic gap: replication and peer review versus realization–conduct–experiment versus *shabda* processed through *manana* and *nididhyasana*.

### 3.6 Personal identity and brain death

Physicalism’s answer to knower **persistence** is typically negative for an immortal individual self. The self is a **biological and cognitive achievement** — developing through embodiment, memory, habit, and social recognition — and **ceasing when brain function ends**. **Brain death** is the operational criterion: personal continuity does not survive the irreversible loss of integrated neural function. No measured post-death continuity of a knowing subject has been established in public science.

**Personal identity** theory asks what, if anything, makes a person the same individual over time. Locke tied identity to **psychological continuity** — memory and connectedness of consciousness — rather than sameness of material particles. Parfit (1984) argued that what matters in survival is psychological connectedness, not a further fact of deep identity beyond the stream of mental states. On reductionist readings, the question “is this the same knower after death?” has no fact of the matter beyond causal and psychological links — which bodily death breaks (SEP Personal Identity).

Madhyasth Darshan’s *jeevan* (§1.14) and Advaita’s eternal *Atman* (§2.4, §2.7) both reject this outcome on different grounds. Physicalism sets a high **evidential bar**: without operational criteria for a non-neural knower or independent post-death evidence, immortal *jeevan* remains a metaphysical posit — while the hard problem (§3.4) shows physicalism’s own exposed point on consciousness.

### 3.7 Method and means of knowing

Modern science inherits methodological naturalism and adds **measurement, formal models, and institutional replication**. Where philosophy disputes mind and knowledge in argument, science operationalises those disputes through instruments, datasets, and peer review. SB records that humans seek to live with evidence through experimentation, behaviour, and experience — not through argument alone (SB, p. 44). Public science is one power-

ful leg of that evidence-seeking; Madhyasth Darshan adds realization and conduct as further evidence ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §4).

The principal **means of knowing** in the naturalistic register do not mirror Indian *pramana* lists exactly, but the functional roles parallel Advaita’s tiered scheme (§2.6.1):

| Modern source                         | Primary role                                         | Limits for mind/self claims                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Perception</b> (incl. instruments) | Data acquisition from world and body                 | Theory-laden; does not directly observe non-physical <i>jeevan</i>                                                                                                |
| <b>Inference and modelling</b>        | Hypothesis, prediction, mathematical structure       | Operates within physicalist ontology unless challenged                                                                                                            |
| <b>Measurement and experiment</b>     | Controlled test of predictions                       | <b>Experiment</b> here means hypothesis-testing and replication — not Madhyasth Darshan’s participatory verification in production and lived orderliness (§1.8.1) |
| <b>Testimony and trust</b>            | Collective knowledge via experts, records, education | Depends on epistemic communities; social virtue epistemology develops this (§3.9)                                                                                 |
| <b>Replication and review</b>         | Error control across communities                     | Third-person; does not substitute for conduct-evidence                                                                                                            |

The **method of knowing** is therefore: observation, instrumentation, mathematical modelling, prediction, replication, and peer review — with **third-person confirmation** as the gold standard. First-person experience is acknowledged as the medium of all knowing (§3.4) but is not treated as existence-proof for immortal units or as sufficient evidence for meta-physical claims without public testability.

### 3.8 Ethics, value, and life’s purpose

Naturalistic ethics does not typically treat justice, dharma, or humane conduct as **part of complete knowledge** in Madhyasth Darshan’s sense (§1.6). Standard accounts explain morality through **evolution** (adaptation and cooperation), **psychology** (empathy, norm internalisation), **social contract**, or **human-constructed values**. Normative realism has defenders, but mainstream science does not treat ethical truths as ontological givens knowable like physical laws.

**Life’s purpose** within this framework is usually **biological survival, reproduction, and adaptation**, supplemented by **human-constructed meaning** — projects, relationships, and cultural narratives. There is no built-in telos of awakening, liberation, or realiza-

tion in coexistence; purpose is not discovered as Madhyasth Darshan's four outcomes (§1.13) or Advaita's *moksha* (§2.7), but assembled from natural and social facts.

This does not mean naturalists cannot live ethically; it means ethics and purpose are **not validated by the same evidence chain** Madhyasth Darshan uses for complete knowing — nor sublated at *paramartha* as in Advaita.

### 3.9 Recent developments beyond simple physicalism

Recent modern philosophy and cognitive science are more diverse than simple brain-reduction. The following developments refine §§3.2–3.7 without replacing the physicalist baseline:

1. **Illusionism and phenomenal realism.** Illusionists argue that phenomenal consciousness, as usually conceived, is a powerful introspective illusion that must be explained rather than accepted as a basic datum (Frankish 2016). Russellian and panpsychist accounts move in the opposite direction: they accept phenomenal consciousness as fundamental or intrinsic to reality (Strawson 2006; Goff 2019; Hashemi 2025).
2. **Predictive processing and the free energy principle.** The knower is a self-organising system that models the causes of sensory input, acts to reduce uncertainty, and maintains itself through active inference — a naturalistic account of agency and “self-evidencing” without positing eternal *jeevan* (Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013; Wiese 2024; Tufft et al. 2024).
3. **Embodied, enactive, and situated selfhood.** 4E approaches treat cognition as embodied, embedded, enacted, and extended. The self is shaped through body, environment, habit, and social practice (IEP Enactivism; Piredda 2024) — closer to Madhyasth Darshan's participation thesis (§1.8.1), though without a constitutionally complete *jeevan*.
4. **Social virtue epistemology.** Recent epistemology stresses trust, testimony, epistemic environments, and collective maintenance of knowledge (Jarczewski and Riggs 2025) — parallel to awakened tradition and *sanskar*-mediated transmission (§1.8.1), with the decisive MD difference that realization evidenced in conduct remains the ultimate proof (§1.8).
5. **Perspectival realism.** Science is always a view from somewhere — historically situated and instrument-mediated — yet still capable of realist knowledge (Massimi 2022). Both perspectival realism and Madhyasth Darshan's *darshan-drishya-drishhti* (§1.4) reject a view-from-nowhere; Madhyasth Darshan adds that right perspective can culminate in realization of coexistence.
6. **Theory pluralism in consciousness science.** Competing programs — global neuronal workspace, integrated information, higher-order, recurrent processing, illusionist, panpsychist — remain unsettled. Adversarial testing of IIT and GNWT partly supported and partly challenged both (Melloni et al. 2025); broad surveys catalogue dozens of rival explanations (Kuhn 2024).

These developments do not remove the major modern objection to Madhyasth Darshan — the lack of publicly measurable evidence for *jeevan*. They do make the comparison more subtle. The live debate is not only “matter versus soul”; it asks whether cognition is brain-bound or embodied, individual or social, representational or enactive, reductive or panpsychist, and whether scientific knowledge is perspective-free or perspectival.

What public science **has** established is precise mechanism, prediction, and correction across many domains. What it **has not** established — on Madhyasth Darshan’s reading — is immortal *jeevan*, realization as ultimate *pramana*, or post-death continuity of a sentient unit (§§1.14, 6.2). An explanatory gap in consciousness is not an existence proof for *jeevan*; predictive accuracy alone does not settle whether the regulator is only neural or a distinct unit working through the brain (§6.3).

## 4. Comparing the Three Views

| Question                          | Madhyasth Darshan                                                                                                                                  | Advaita Vedanta                                                                                                                    | Modern Science & Philosophy                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>What is Knowledge?</b>         | Realization of coexistence, unfolding as <i>gyan-vivek-vigyan</i> and humane conduct; four distinct senses of <i>gyan</i> (§1.1.1)                 | Direct realization of Atman-Brahman identity; non-dual awareness ( <i>jnana-svarupa</i> )                                          | Justified true belief; predictive neural models of physical reality                             |
| <b>Four senses of <i>gyan</i></b> | Realisation Knowledge, <i>gyan</i> as <i>satta</i> , realisation in coexistence, <i>gyan udghatan</i> — kept distinct (§1.1.1)                     | <i>Jnana</i> as Brahman / Self; world is appearance                                                                                | No parallel taxonomy; experience may be physical, fundamental, or illusory                      |
| <b>Who is the Knower?</b>         | Active sentient <i>jeevan</i> operating through the body; human evidences seer-status ( <i>drishta-pad</i> ); persists across bodily death (§1.14) | Actionless Witness Self ( <i>Atman / sakshi</i> ); individual knower ( <i>jiva</i> ) is provisionally real but ultimately sublated | Evolved biological organism (brain-mind complex); the “self” is an emergent cognitive construct |



| Question                      | Madhyasth Darshan                                                                                                                       | Advaita Vedanta                                                                                    | Modern Science & Philosophy                                                                                           |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>What is the Known?</b>     | Existence as coexistence: Omnipresence, all units, four orders, relationships, values, humane conduct                                   | The empirical world ( <i>drishya</i> ), ultimately <i>mithya</i> (dependent appearance)            | The objective physical universe (matter, energy, space, time)                                                         |
| <b>Basic Structure</b>        | <i>Darshan-drishya-drishti</i> : right perspective sees the real scene and becomes holistic view                                        | <i>Drig-drishya-viveka</i> : seer-seen discrimination negates the seen to reveal the witness       | Subject-object modelling: observer builds public, testable models of objects/events                                   |
| <b>Is the World Real?</b>     | Yes. “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual.”                                                                                         | Provisionally ( <i>vyavaharika</i> ), yes; absolutely ( <i>paramarthika</i> ), no.                 | Yes, for scientific realism and physicalism; methodologically, it is treated as publicly observable and law-governed. |
| <b>Method of Knowing</b>      | Staged study → experiment and practice → realisation with evidence in conduct (§1.8.1)                                                  | Scripture ( <i>shravana</i> ), reasoning ( <i>manana</i> ), and meditation ( <i>nididhyasana</i> ) | Observation, experiment, mathematical modeling, prediction, and replication                                           |
| <b>Means of Valid Knowing</b> | Study and realization ( <i>anubhav</i> ) as the ultimate <i>pramana</i> , proven by <i>pramanikta</i> and ability to impart (§1.6–§1.8) | Six <i>pramanas</i> , but <i>shabda</i> (revelation) alone reaches non-duality                     | Perception, inference, measurement, testimony, replication; JTB analysis contested (§3.7)                             |
| <b>Account of Error</b>       | Delusion ( <i>bhram</i> ), intellectual mystery, false learning — removable through aligned knowing (§§1.6.1, 1.10–1.11)                | <i>Khyativada</i> : <i>anirvacaniya</i> projection on Brahman, sublated by knowledge               | Perceptual/cognitive bias and false belief, corrected by replication and peer review (§3.5)                           |
| <b>Knower persistence</b>     | <i>Jeevan</i> immortal; post-death continuity inferred, not measured (§1.14)                                                            | Self is eternal Brahman; individual <i>jiva</i> sublated at liberation                             | Personal end at brain death; no individual survival (§3.6)                                                            |

| Question                          | Madhyasth Darshan                                                                         | Advaita Vedanta                                                                               | Modern Science & Philosophy                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Recent Modern Alternatives</b> | Can be compared with MD's active <i>jeevan</i> , conduct-evidence, and awakened tradition | Can be compared with Advaita's witness and no-self tendencies                                 | Predictive processing, enactivism, social epistemology, perspectival realism, illusionism, IIT/GNWT, and panpsychism (§3.9) |
| <b>Status of Ethics</b>           | Humane conduct is part of complete knowledge and its evidence                             | Ethics purifies the mind and operates within provisional reality                              | Ethics is explained through evolution, psychology, social contract, or human values (§3.8)                                  |
| <b>Life's Purpose</b>             | Awakening: resolution, prosperity, harmony, and coexistence in society                    | Liberation ( <i>moksha</i> ): freedom from birth and death by realizing identity with Brahman | Biological survival, adaptation, and human-constructed meaning (§3.8)                                                       |

## 4.1 Key contrasts

- 1. Reality of the World:** Advaita Vedanta treats the world as *mithya* — provisionally valid but not absolutely real — to safeguard the absolute non-duality of Brahman. Madhyasth Darshan rejects this, asserting that both Brahma (Space) and the world (material and sentient units) are real: *Brahma satya hai, jagat satat hai*. Modern science also affirms the reality of the physical world, but does not accept Space as omnipresent knowledge.
- 2. Two Different Seer-Scene Structures:** Advaita's *drig-drishya* method separates the seer from the seen and keeps negating the seen until only the actionless witness remains. Madhyasth Darshan's *darshan-drishya-drishti* structure asks whether the human perspective can see the scene as coexistence and then evidence that understanding in conduct. Modern science treats the observer as a biological system that constructs public, testable models of observable events (§3.3).
- 3. Active vs. Passive Knower:** In Advaita, the true Self is an actionless witness (*sakshi* / *akriya*). In Madhyasth Darshan, the knower (*jeevan*) is active, possessing structure, hope, thought, desire, evaluation, and the capacity for realization. In modern science, the knower is a dynamic, evolving biological system (§3.2).
- 4. Knowledge must become conduct.** In Madhyasth Darshan, *gyan* must unfold as *vivek* and *vigyan*, and then become evident through realization, behaviour, and experiment (§1.8.1). Advaita's highest knowledge culminates in liberation through recognition of Brahman (§2.7), not conduct-evidence in a perpetual world. Modern science's knowledge culminates in predictive control, explanation, and replicable

models — where **experiment** means hypothesis-testing and replication, not MD’s participation in orderliness through production and lived verification (§3.7).

5. **The Status of Space:** In modern physics, space-time is a physical structure described mathematically (§3.3). In Advaita, space (*akasha*) belongs to the order of appearance and is therefore *mithya*. In Madhyasth Darshan, Space (*shunya / vyapak*) is eternal, omnipresent, all-pervasive knowledge and energy itself, but not an individual conscious unit.
6. **Where Recent Modern Views Come Closer to MD:** Predictive processing and enactivism make the knower active and embodied; social virtue epistemology makes knowledge socially maintained; perspectival realism makes knowledge perspective-dependent but not merely subjective (§3.9). These partially resemble Madhyasth Darshan’s active seer, conduct-evidence, and perspective structure. The decisive difference remains ontological: these modern views generally do not accept *jeevan* as a real, eternal sentient unit.
7. **How each explains valid knowing and error.** Madhyasth Darshan makes realization the ultimate proof and treats error as a *removable* misidentification of *jeevan* with the body, propagating as intellectual mystery — misaligned reflection among the knower’s faculties (§1.11.1) — and as false learning when doubt and mis-evaluation block *pramanikta* (§1.6.1). Advaita reserves ultimate competence for revelation (*shabda*) and treats error — and the world itself — as *anirvacaniya* appearance sublated by knowledge. Modern science trusts measurement and replication and treats error as bias or false belief (§3.5), while conceding (since Gettier) that even “justified true belief” may not capture knowledge (§3.1). The contrast is sharpest on mystery: Madhyasth Darshan claims it is fully eliminable through holistic view and aligned knowing; Advaita relocates it beyond the sayable; science leaves the Hard Problem open (§3.4).

## 4.2 Sat-Chit-Ananda versus distributed coexistence

Advaita’s Sat-Chit-Ananda and Madhyasth Darshan’s coexistence can sound alike — both speak of being, consciousness, and fulfilment. The contrast is over what those words name and whether the world survives them ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §5.6).

| Concept            | Advaita Vedanta<br>(unified non-dualism)                                              | Madhyasth Darshan (distributed<br>coexistence)                                                 |
|--------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sat (Being)</b> | Brahman alone is <i>sat</i> ; the world is a dependent appearance ultimately negated. | Beingness ( <i>astitva</i> ) is coexistence of formless Omnipresence and countless real units. |

| Concept                         | Advaita Vedanta<br>(unified non-dualism)                                        | Madhyasth Darshan (distributed<br>coexistence)                                                                                                        |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Chit<br/>(Consciousness)</b> | Pure awareness, identical to the inner Self; the world of names/forms is inert. | Omnipresence is pervasive knowledge/condition-of-intelligibility (§1.1), but active sentience ( <i>chaitanya</i> ) belongs to the <i>jeevan</i> unit. |
| <b>Ananda (Bliss)</b>           | Intrinsic nature of Brahman; sensory joy is a distorted reflection.             | Harmony realized within the awakened <i>jeevan</i> , expressed as humane conduct.                                                                     |

Modern philosophy has no parallel formula: it may treat experience as physical, fundamental, or illusory, but it does not name existence as Sat-Chit-Ananda or as coexistence.

### 4.3 Partially incommensurable epistemic criteria

The three systems do not merely give different answers; they use different criteria for what counts as knowing ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §6.5):

| Tradition         | Method                                                                | Adequate for                                                     |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Madhyasth Darshan | Study, realization, behaviour, experiment                             | Coexistence as lived evidence; conduct as proof of understanding |
| Advaita           | Scripture, reasoning, contemplative discrimination (§§2.1, 2.6–2.6.1) | Self as Brahman; sublation of <i>mithya</i>                      |
| Physicalism       | Observation, modelling, replication, peer review (§3.7)               | Mechanism, prediction, third-person confirmation                 |

To that extent they are **partially incommensurable** — no single neutral tribunal settles them. What comparative work can still do is test each for internal consistency, fit with public knowledge, and responsible distinction of posits from bare assertion. The open epistemic disputes are collected in §6.

## 5. Critical Review

No view escapes serious objections. Here is where each is strong and where each is vulnerable.

### 5.1 Madhyasth Darshan — integrated inside, unproven outside

**Strengths.** It offers a realistic, positive framework that validates human relationships, ethics, and ecological balance as absolutely real. Its structure is unusually integrated: ontology (Space and units), epistemology (*darshan-drishya-drishhti*, four senses of *gyan*), self-

knowledge (*jeevan*), practical wisdom (*gyan-vivek-vigyan*), staged study, and conduct-evidence are tied to one chain. It avoids Advaita's difficult task of explaining how a dependent world feels so real, and it avoids the "combination problem" of panpsychism by defining the self as a single, indivisible, constitutionally complete atom.

**Weaknesses.** The axiomatic claim that Space is Knowledge cannot be verified by physical measurement alone. The interaction between *jeevan* and the brain remains contested against causal closure (§1.12.1). The system risks unfalsifiability if any failure to verify is attributed only to lack of awakening. The full-knowability thesis is unusually strong even with MVD Ch. 17's internal account (§1.11). Conduct-evidence and realization do not yet meet public science's evidential bar (§6.2). Open epistemological disputes are developed in §6.

Madhyasth Darshan is best read as an internally integrated epistemology whose decisive tests remain conduct-based and publicly contestable, not as a demonstrated ontology.

## 5.2 Advaita Vedanta — rigorous witness, steep price

**Strengths.** It is highly rigorous and starts from the most undeniable fact of human existence: first-person consciousness itself. Its method of negating the observed to find the observer (*neti neti*) is a powerful introspective practice.

**Weaknesses.**

- **The status of ethics.** If the world and individuality are ultimately unreal (*mithya*), then ethical action and human suffering also have only provisional value. This makes it difficult to build a robust foundation for social and ecological responsibility.
- **The ignorance paradox.** If only Brahman exists and is pure knowledge, where does the ignorance (*avidya*) that creates the illusion of the world come from? Advaita's explanation that ignorance is "indescribable" (*anirvacaniya*) is often criticized as a logical evasion — the same move used to explain a single perceptual error (rope-snake) is stretched to cover all of cosmic ignorance, which critics see as naming a mystery rather than resolving it.

Advaita can reply fairly on ethics: at *vyavahara*, compassion, duty, and *loka-sangraha* remain binding (§2.8). The Madhyasth counter-reply is not that Advaitins cannot live ethically, but that an ontology sublating the world at *paramartha* cannot match coexistence's final weight for relationships and nature. Advaita is the most radical and in one way the most rigorous answer on the knower — but its rigor is purchased by declaring unanswerable many questions about the world we actually live in.

## 5.3 Modern science and philosophy — powerful method, unfinished story

**Strengths.** It has delivered unmatched predictive power, medicine, and technology. Its self-correcting methodology of replication and peer review is the most successful system for eliminating subjective bias (§3.5).

## Weaknesses.

- **The hard problem.** Science has failed to explain how objective, physical brain processes (like neurons firing) can produce subjective, qualitative experience (like seeing red or feeling love) (§3.4).
- **First-person blindness.** By treating first-person subjective experience as something to be explained from the outside, science can understate the evidential importance of the very medium through which all observations are made (§3.4).
- **Fragmentation.** Recent philosophy of mind and consciousness science have many live but competing accounts — illusionism, panpsychism, predictive processing, enactivism, IIT, GNWT, higher-order theories, and others (§3.9). This pluralism is intellectually healthy, but it also means modern philosophy has no unified answer to the knower-known-knowledge triad.

Scientific materialism offers the strongest method and the best-supported account of public evidence — but its claim to be the *complete* account of knowledge and the knower is a philosophical position, not a scientific finding.

## 6. Open problems for Madhyasth Darshan (epistemology)

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The items below are numbered **6.1–6.5** for cross-reference. They state what remains open within Madhyasth Darshan’s epistemology and at its boundary with public science and rival traditions.

### 6.1 Full-knowability versus fallibilism

Madhyasth Darshan holds that existence is fully knowable and that mystery is a removable deficit of understanding (§1.11). MVD Ch. 17 supplies an internal mechanism — intellectual mystery as faculty misalignment, exploration and tradition-following, four supports for reflection. A critic can still ask how one could ever know that **all** of existence has been understood, and whether *certitude* is guaranteed by definition rather than earned by inquiry. The dispute with fallibilist epistemology — which treats even our best theories as corrigible — is not settled here.

### 6.2 Evidential bar versus public science

Realization and conduct are cited as proof; science requires public testability. Public science would require at minimum ([The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §6.4.2):

1. **Operational criteria** for constitutional completeness independent of the philosophy.
2. **Reproducible markers** distinguishing *jeevan*-mediated from brain-only activity.
3. **Independent evidence** for post-death continuity of a sentient unit.

Until then, claims about immortal *jeevan* and realization as *pramana* remain metaphysical assertions compatible with coexistence conservation but not validated by current science —

while the hard problem shows physicalism’s own exposed point. An explanatory gap in consciousness is not by itself an existence proof for *jeevan*; physicalists treat it as philosophically non-decisive while Madhyasth Darshan reads it as ontological incompleteness in matter-only accounts.

### 6.3 *Jeevan*–body interaction and causal closure

If *jeevan* coordinates the body through the joint form (§1.12.1), physicalist readers still face an interaction problem: either *jeevan* exerts measurable influence on neural tissue, or “drives” names a non-mechanical mode the texts have not fully specified in modern vocabulary. State-and-order transmission spares the naive Cartesian picture but does not settle Kim-style **causal closure**. Full treatment belongs in the planned *Philosophy-Of-Mind-And-Jeevan* study.

### 6.4 Post-death continuity as inference, not measurement

Post-death survival of *jeevan* is inferred from conservation and constitutional immortality (§1.14), not established by third-person observation. The category error — conflating quantity conservation with entity persistence — is the sharpest friction with public science. Madhyasth Darshan’s reply (weight-bondage exit at constitutional completeness) is ontological; physics and mereology are developed in [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) §6.2.4.

### 6.5 Partially incommensurable criteria of knowing

The three traditions use different criteria for adequate knowing (§4.3). Madhyasth Darshan adds realization and conduct as evidence beyond mechanism and prediction; Advaita reserves ultimate competence for revelation and contemplative discrimination; physicalism trusts observation and replication. No single neutral tribunal settles them. Comparative work can still test internal consistency, fit with public knowledge, and responsible distinction of posits from bare assertion — but the epistemic standoff at the boundary is real, not a temporary gap in translation.

## Appendix: Quick Glossary

Key terms from §§1–3 are collected here for quick reference. Each term is also defined where it first appears in the exposition.

### Terms in §1

| Term                                     | Plain meaning                                                                                                |
|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Coexistence (<i>saha-astitva</i>)</b> | Reality as the pervasive ground ( <i>satta</i> ) and all units ( <i>ikai</i> ) inseparably present together. |



| Term                                           | Plain meaning                                                                                                                                                                         |
|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Anubhav jnan (Realisation Knowledge)</b>    | The ontological given in saturated units — form, properties, essential nature, <i>dharma</i> , and orderliness (MVD, p. 11; §1.1.1).                                                  |
| <b>Gyan udghatan</b>                           | The unfolding of knowledge — an activity exclusive to awakened <i>jeevan</i> , not Omnipresence or insentient units (§1.1.1).                                                         |
| <b>Gyan-vivek-vigyan</b>                       | Knowledge, wisdom/discrimination, and science/systematic know-how — the way understanding becomes evaluation and practical participation.                                             |
| <b>Darshan-drishya-drishhti</b>                | Madhyasth Darshan's structure of worldview, scene, and perspective: the perceiver uses perspective to see the real scene and arrive at holistic understanding.                        |
| <b>Sapēkshata (Relativity)</b>                 | Epistemological relativity arising from distinctions among perspective, scene, and worldview — real within units and understanding, not a feature of underlying coexistence (§1.4.1). |
| <b>Sanvedansheelta / *sangyansheelta*</b>      | Sensitivity (body- and sense-based responsiveness) and comprehension/cognisance (the understanding proper to <i>jeevan</i> ) — the two modes of engaging the world.                   |
| <b>Pramana</b>                                 | Means or proof of valid knowledge; in Madhyasth Darshan, realization ( <i>anubhav</i> ) evidenced in conduct is the ultimate proof.                                                   |
| <b>Pramanikta (Authenticity / evidence)</b>    | Conduct and living that evidences realization — the outward test of complete knowing (§1.6, §1.6.1).                                                                                  |
| <b>Bhram</b>                                   | Delusion — living by inherited belief rather than understanding, rooted in identifying <i>jeevan</i> with the body.                                                                   |
| <b>Rahasyata (Mysteriousness)</b>              | Incapacity to reveal or attain complete understanding — not an ontological opacity in coexistence (§1.11).                                                                            |
| <b>Bauddhik rahasya (Intellectual mystery)</b> | Misalignment among <i>mun</i> , <i>vritti</i> , <i>chitta</i> , and <i>buddhi</i> when lower faculties do not take refuge in the one above (§1.11.1).                                 |
| <b>Anushandhan (Exploration)</b>               | Inventive comprehensive study from decline through development to omnipresence (MVD, Ch. 17; §1.11.2).                                                                                |
| <b>Jeevan</b>                                  | The sentient self — in Shri Nagraj's view a real, eternal, atom-scale entity that works <i>through</i> the body. Ontology: <a href="#">The Ontology of Coexistence</a> .              |

| Term                                    | Plain meaning                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b><i>Drishta-pad</i> (Seer status)</b> | The unique capacity of the human being in existence to observe, understand, and evaluate all orders of nature. |

## Terms in §2

| Term                                   | Plain meaning                                                                              |
|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b><i>Atman</i> / *<i>Brahman</i>*</b> | In Advaita Vedanta: the innermost Self / the one ultimate, non-dual reality.               |
| <b>Sat-Chit-Ananda</b>                 | Advaita: being, consciousness, and bliss as three names of one Brahman.                    |
| <b><i>Chit</i></b>                     | Advaita: consciousness as the very nature of Brahman and the inner Self.                   |
| <b><i>Svaprakasha</i></b>              | Advaita: consciousness self-luminous — reveals itself without another knower (§2.2).       |
| <b><i>Badha</i> (Sublation)</b>        | Advaita: discovery that what seemed absolutely real was dependent on a substrate (§2.2.1). |
| <b><i>Mithya</i></b>                   | Advaita's term for the world: dependent, provisional appearance, not absolutely real.      |
| <b><i>Moksha</i></b>                   | Advaita: liberation as recognition of pre-existing identity with Brahman (§2.7).           |

## Terms in §3

| Term                      | Plain meaning                                                                                                                                                       |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Scientific realism</b> | The view that the physical world is mind-independent and law-governed, suitable for public investigation (§3.3).                                                    |
| <b>Hard Problem</b>       | Why physical brain processes are accompanied by subjective experience — a modern open question, not the same as Madhyasth Darshan's <i>rahasyata</i> (§1.11; §3.4). |

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- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. [\*Madhyasth Darshan – Co-existentialism, Part 1: Holistic View of Human Behaviour\*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: all units in Omnipresence (p. 11); evidence chain and “Believe what is known” (p. 12); “Only

awakened humans” (p. 33); Space as knowledge and *gyan-vivek-vigyan* (p. 35, 143, 155); threefold truth (p. 37); *sanskar* definition (p. 90); *medhas* and activities of *jeevan* (p. 83); *darshan-drishya-drishti* (p. 84); knowledge unfolding by awakened humans (p. 115); “Realisation in coexistence” (p. 116); false learning (pp. 263–264); mystery and certitude (p. 209); Ch. 17 *Rahasya-mukti* – mystery, intellectual mystery, paths, four supports, liberation as bliss (pp. 273–301); knowledge unfolding through *jeevan* /thoughts (p. 289); awakening–*sanskar* cycle (p. 290); “Realisation in knowledge” (p. 316); “delusion-less knowledge” (p. 317); “Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual” (*The Alternative*, point 8).

- **SB** – Nagraj, A. [\*Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad \(Resolution Centred Materialism\)\*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: Balance of cognisance and sensitivity (p. 64); Threefold knowledge (p. 116); *satta* naming (p. 48); conservation (p. 49); realisation in coexistence (p. 51); evidence through experimentation, behaviour, and experience (p. 44); Human as seer (p. 188); Seer-status in existence (p. 239).
- **JV** – Nagraj, A. [\*Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction\*](#). English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: Proof by conveying understanding (p. 26); human body provisioned to evidence understanding (p. 59); birth, death, and *jeevan* continuity (p. 20); values and evaluation not bodily processes (p. 39); *jeevan* evaluates without external instrument (p. 139); ten activities of *jeevan* (p. 92); root of delusion and belief-vs-knowledge (p. 93); definition of knowledge (p. 165); purview of sensitivity (p. 166).

## Advaita Vedanta (primary texts)

- **BG** – [\*Bhagavad Gita\*](#). Cited: field and knower of the field (13.1–13.2); ordained duty and *loka-sangraha* (3.8).
- **BU** – [\*Brihadaranyaka Upanishad\*](#). Cited: *neti neti* (2.3.6); *shravana–manana–nididhyasana* (2.4.5).
- **DDV** – [\*Drig-Drishya-Viveka\*](#) (attributed to Shankara or Bharati Tirtha). Cited: Seer and seen discrimination (p. 15).
- **BSB** – Shankara, Adi. [\*Brahma Sutra Bhashya\*](#). Cited: the *Adhyasa Bhashya* (preamble) on superimposition of self and not-self; *tat tvam asi* doctrine (1.1.2).
- **CU** – [\*Chandogya Upanishad\*](#). Cited: clay analogy (6.1.4); “one only, without a second” (6.2.1); *tat tvam asi* (6.8.7).
- **MU** – [\*Mandukya Upanishad\*](#). Cited: three states and *turiya* (vv. 3–7).
- **TU** – [\*Taittiriya Upanishad\*](#). Cited: Brahman as Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity (2.1.1); five sheaths (2.1–2.5).
- **VC** – [\*Vivekachudamani\*](#) (attributed to Shankara). Cited: ethical discipline as prerequisite (vv. 17–19); discrimination between real and unreal (v. 20); five sheaths (vv. 154–212); Existence-Knowledge-Bliss (v. 152); Maya and Avidya (vv. 243–244); *jiva* as Brahman (v. 216); Brahman as one’s own Self (v. 393); liberation without seeker or bound soul (v. 574).

## Related studies in this collection

- [The Ontology of Coexistence](#) — “Knowledge but not knower” (§1.11), projection–reflection cycle and intellectual mystery (§1.9), Sat-Chit-Ananda contrast (§5.6), epistemic incommensurability (§6.5), Saturation-Reflector Model (§6.6), evidence standards (§6.4).
- [Human Behavior and Society](#) — manifest, effable knowledge versus mystery-based ineffability (§3).
- *Spiritual-Practice-And-Realization* (Ongoing) — *dhyan*, yoga, six flaws, and the practice path deferred from §1.11.2.

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